

The Prophet -The Role Model: Truthfulness in Speech

إن الحمد لله نحمده ونستعينه ونستغفره، ونعوذ بالله من شرور أنفسنا، ومن سيئات أعمالنا، من يهده الله فلا مضل له، ومن يضل فلا هادي له، وأشهد أن لا إله إلا الله وحده لا شريك له، وأشهد أن سيدنا محمداً عبده ورسوله، اللهم صل وسلم وبارك على سيدنا محمد وعلى آله وأصحابه ومن تبعه إلى يوم الدين

يَا أَيُّهَا الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا اتَّقُوا اللَّهَ حَقَّ تُقَاتِهِ وَلَا تَمُوتُنَّ إِلَّا وَأَنْتُمْ مُسْلِمُونَ [آل عمران:102]، أما بعد فإن أصدق الحديث كتاب الله، وأحسن الهدي هدي محمد، وشر الأمور محدثاتها، وكل محدثة بدعة، وكل بدعة ضلالة، وكل ضلالة في النار

Allah commanded us to look to the Messenger of Allah ﷺ as our model in building our character:

﴿لَقَدْ كَانَ لَكُمْ فِي رَسُولِ اللَّهِ أُسْوَةٌ حَسَنَةٌ﴾ [سورة الأحزاب، الآية 21]

“Indeed, in the Messenger of Allah you have an excellent example.” [Al-Ahzab, 33:21]

When Sayeda Aishah رضي الله عنها was asked about the character of the Messenger of Allah ﷺ, she gave one of the most profound descriptions of him: **“His character was the Qur’an.”**

He ﷺ did not merely teach the Qur’an. He lived it.

So, if we want to build our character according to his example, we must first ask: What are the elements of the character that the Qur’an calls us to develop?

The answer becomes clear when we remember that the Prophet ﷺ was the finest example of the believer, the muttaqi, the servant of Allah, and the wali of Allah. Therefore, we can turn to the verses in the Quran in which Allah describes the believers, the muttaqun, His righteous servants, and His awliya.

When we collect these descriptions, we find about fifty traits that can be organized into ten broad categories:

1. Sound Belief
2. Sincere Worship
3. Repentance, Gratitude, and Striving Against the Self
4. Generosity and Financial Integrity
5. Truthfulness and Noble Character
6. Patience, Forgiveness, and Mercy
7. Social Responsibility and Community Life
8. Justice, Fairness, and Upholding Rights
9. Chastity, Family, and Lawful Living
10. Striving in the Cause of Allah

I will not go through all the Qur'anic verses that establish these traits today. They are discussed in my book Tadabbur of the Quran through the Lens of Key Terms, which is available as a free PDF on my website: <https://www.successineterernity.org/> under the "Books" tab.

But identifying the traits is only the first step. We must then ask: **What do these traits look like when they are actually lived?**

For that, we turn to the Messenger of Allah ﷺ. The Qur'an gives us the qualities, and the Prophet ﷺ gives us their living example. Then we can turn the question toward ourselves: **How closely does my character reflect his example?**

Today, insha'Allah, I want to consider one of the traits under the broad category of **Truthfulness and Noble Character**. In future khutbahs, insha'Allah, we can consider other traits.

The trait that we will consider is **truthfulness in speech and dealings**.

The believer should be truthful in speech, promises, and dealings until truthfulness becomes a settled quality by which he is known. People should not have to test our words every time we speak. Our honesty should not change depending on whom we are dealing with or what we stand to gain.

Allah says:

﴿يَا أَيُّهَا الَّذِينَ ءَامَنُوا اتَّقُوا اللَّهَ وَقُولُوا قَوْلًا سَدِيدًا﴾

"O you who believe, be mindful of Allah and speak words that are right and true."
[Al-Ahzab, 33:70]

﴿يَا أَيُّهَا الَّذِينَ ءَامَنُوا اتَّقُوا اللَّهَ وَكُونُوا مَعَ الصَّادِقِينَ﴾

"O you who believe, be mindful of Allah and be with the truthful." [At-Tawbah, 9:119]

Notice that the Qur'an does not merely tell us to speak the truth on a particular occasion. It says: ﴿وَكُونُوا مَعَ الصَّادِقِينَ﴾ **"Be with the truthful"**. Truthfulness is not simply something we do. It becomes part of who we are.

And the Qur'anic expression **qawlan sadida** (قَوْلًا سَدِيدًا) means more than simply avoiding lies. It is speech that is straight and sound, speech that is not bent by desire, fear, or self-interest.

Now let us see what this quality looked like in the life of the Prophet ﷺ. When Allah revealed:

﴿وَأَنْذِرْ عَشِيرَتَكَ الْأَقْرَبِينَ﴾ الشُّعْرَاءُ

"And warn your closest kindred." (Al-Shuara 26:214)

the Prophet ﷺ climbed Mount Safa and called the clans of Quraysh until they gathered before him. He then asked them: **“If I were to tell you that cavalry in the valley was about to attack you, would you believe me?”**

They replied: **“Yes. “We have never known you to lie.”**

He then said: **“Then I am a warner to you before a severe punishment.”** Narrated by Al-Bukhari and Muslim.

The power of this moment lies not only in what the Prophet ﷺ said that day, but in **the forty years that came before it.**

Had he spent those years lying, deceiving, breaking promises, or manipulating people, his opponents would have had the perfect opportunity to expose him. But they could not.

These were not merely his followers praising him. Among those standing before him were people who would become fierce opponents of his message. Yet when asked about something they had personally witnessed throughout his life, they had to admit: **“We have never known you to lie.”**

This teaches us the power of **accumulated truthfulness.**

A person does not create a reputation for honesty on the day he suddenly needs one. He builds it **word by word, promise by promise, transaction by transaction**, until his past conduct speaks for him before he even speaks.

There is another remarkable testimony.

Before Abu Sufyan accepted Islam, he was among the strongest opponents of the Prophet ﷺ. While he was in Syria, Heraclius questioned him about Muhammad ﷺ. Among his questions was: **“Did you ever accuse him of lying before he said what he now says?”** Abu Sufyan answered: **No.** (Narrated by Al-Bukhari)

Think about this. Abu Sufyan was speaking about a man whose message he was actively opposing. If he could truthfully have discredited him before a powerful ruler, this was the opportunity. Yet he could not accuse him of lying.

Heraclius then reasoned that a man who had never been known to lie about people was not likely suddenly to invent a lie about Allah.

Thus, the Prophet's ﷺ character **before revelation became evidence supporting his message after revelation.** And this brings the lesson directly to us.

أقول قولي هذا واستغفر الله العظيم لي ولكم ولسائر المسلمين من كل ذنب فاستغفروه إنه هو الغفور الرحيم

الحمد لله وأشهد أن لا إله إلا الله وحده لا شريك له ، وأشهد أن سيدنا محمدًا عبده ورسوله ، صلى الله عليه وعلى آله وأصحابه ومن سار على نهجهم واهتدى بهديهم .أما بعد: .عباد الله: أوصيكم ونفسي بتقوى الله

Suppose someone who has known you for twenty or thirty years, someone who has dealt with you in business, money, family matters, work, and disagreement, were asked today: **“Have you ever known this person to lie?”** What would the answer be?

Do people trust what you say because they have repeatedly experienced your truthfulness, or do you have to keep asking them to trust you?

The Prophet ﷺ was so consistently truthful that even his opponents had to testify to his honesty. That is the standard toward which the believer should strive:

Live with such consistent truthfulness that your honesty does not need the testimony of your friends, because even those who disagree with you cannot truthfully accuse you of lying.

اللهم صلّ وسلم وبارك على سيدنا محمد وعلى آله وأصحابه
اللهم اهدنا فيمن هديت ، وعافنا فيمن عافيت ، وتولنا فيمن توليت ، وبارك لنا فيما أعطيت ، وقنا
واصرف عنا شر ما قضيت ، فإنك تقضي بالحق ، ولا يقضى عليك ،
لهم وأدخلنا برحمتك في عبادك الصالحين ، أخرجنا من ظلمات الجهل والوهم إلى أنوار العلم
اللهم اجعلنا ممن يستمعون القول فيتبعون أحسنه
اللهم بفضلك ورحمتك أعل كلمة الحق والدين ، وانصر الإسلام ، وأعز المسلمين يا أكرم الأكرمين .

O Allah, spread your mercy upon us, shower us with Your blessings, increase our knowledge, grant us forgiveness, and reward us by the company of Your prophets in the highest place in Heaven, Al-Ferdous Al-Aala.

O Allah, forgive our parents and all our friends and relatives who have passed away and make their graves a garden from heaven and grant them the Ferdous Al-Ala.

O Allah, remedy our sick and grant them full and speedy recovery.

O Allah, guide our children, protect them and make them righteous.

O Allah we have many of our brethren who are suffering from injustice and oppression, O Allah grant them victory, heal their trauma, protect the helpless, fulfill their needs and grant them peace and prosperity.

O Allah, we ask you in this blessed hour with every name you have elected for yourself that none of us leave this gathering, but his pains have been relieved, his worries have been removed, his debts have been paid, his weaknesses have been concealed, his sins have been forgiven, and his needs have been fulfilled,

إِنَّ اللَّهَ وَمَلَائِكَتَهُ يُصَلُّونَ عَلَى النَّبِيِّ يَا أَيُّهَا الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا صَلُّوا عَلَيْهِ وَسَلِّمُوا تَسْلِيمًا (الأحزاب 33:56)
اللهم صلّ وسلم وبارك على سيدنا محمد وعلى آله وأصحابه
وَأَقِمِ الصَّلَاةَ إِنَّ الصَّلَاةَ تَنْهَى عَنِ الْفَحْشَاءِ وَالْمُنْكَرِ